EVOFIT MEALS NUTRITION GUIDE

The Intermittent Fasting Protocol Guide

16:8, 20:4, OMAD — When to Use Which

16:8 Daily | 20:4 Warrior | OMAD | 5:2 Weekly | Alternate Day

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CHAPTER 01

How Fasting Works

Understanding the metabolic cascade that happens when you stop eating — and why the timing matters as much as the food itself.

Insulin Sensitivity

When you fast, insulin levels drop significantly. Low insulin signals your body to switch from glucose-burning to fat-burning mode. Over time, regular fasting improves your cells' response to insulin, making nutrient partitioning more efficient and reducing fat storage from meals.

Autophagy

Your body's cellular recycling program. During extended fasting (16+ hours), cells begin breaking down and recycling damaged proteins and organelles. This process clears out dysfunctional mitochondria, misfolded proteins, and cellular debris — essentially taking out the biological trash.

Growth Hormone Spike

Fasting can increase human growth hormone (HGH) secretion by 300–500%. HGH preserves lean muscle tissue during calorie restriction, accelerates fat metabolism, and supports tissue repair. This is why fasting paired with resistance training preserves muscle.

Fat Oxidation

After glycogen stores deplete (12–16 hours), your body upregulates lipolysis — the breakdown of stored triglycerides into free fatty acids. These fatty acids are then oxidized in the mitochondria for energy. You become a more efficient fat-burning machine.

Fasting Timeline: What Happens at Each Stage

0 – 12 Hours

Fed State → Post-Absorptive State

Blood sugar and insulin normalize. Liver glycogen begins depleting. Your body still primarily uses glucose for fuel. By hour 12, glycogen stores are roughly 50% depleted and the metabolic switch to fat begins.

12 – 16 Hours

Fat-Burning Zone Begins

Insulin drops to baseline. Lipolysis accelerates. Ketone body production starts in the liver. Norepinephrine rises, increasing alertness and metabolic rate by 3.6–14%. Mild autophagy begins in most tissues.

16 – 24 Hours

Deep Ketosis & Autophagy

Significant autophagy activation. Growth hormone surges (up to 5x baseline). Ketone levels reach 0.5–2.0 mmol/L. Brain begins preferring ketones for fuel. Anti-inflammatory gene expression increases. Gut lining begins repair cycle.

24 – 36 Hours

Maximum Autophagy

Peak cellular cleanup. AMPK (cellular energy sensor) is fully activated. Old immune cells are cleared for recycling. Stem cell regeneration signals begin. Insulin sensitivity reaches optimal levels. Not recommended for beginners.

36 – 48 Hours

Extended Repair & Reset

Immune system regeneration accelerates. Significant reduction in inflammatory markers (CRP, IL-6). Neuroplasticity and BDNF (brain-derived neurotrophic factor) increase. Only for experienced fasters under medical guidance. Electrolyte management becomes critical.

CHAPTER 02

5 Fasting Protocols Compared

Not all fasting is created equal. Each protocol has specific strengths, ideal use cases, and populations who should avoid it.

Protocol	Eating Window	Difficulty	Best For	Not Recommended For
16:8 Daily Fast	8 hours e.g., 12pm–8pm	Easy	Beginners, sustainable fat loss, general health improvement, muscle maintenance, anyone with a busy morning schedule	Pregnant/nursing women, those with history of eating disorders, type 1 diabetics without medical supervision
20:4 Warrior Diet	4 hours e.g., 4pm–8pm	Moderate	Aggressive fat loss, plateau-breaking, experienced dieters who want faster results, improved autophagy	Beginners, those with high caloric needs (3000+ kcal), athletes in heavy training blocks, underweight individuals
OMAD One Meal a Day	1 hour e.g., 6pm–7pm	Hard	Experienced fasters, maximum autophagy, simplicity seekers, those who prefer one large meal, short-term fat loss sprints	Beginners, anyone building muscle, those who can't consume 2000+ kcal in one sitting, adolescents, elderly
5:2 Weekly Fast	5 normal days 2 days at 500–600 kcal	Moderate	Flexible lifestyles, social eaters, those who dislike daily restriction, slow-and-steady fat loss, metabolic health	Those who binge on "normal" days, people who need daily consistency, high-performance athletes during competition prep
ADF Alternate Day	Alternating Eat → Fast → Eat	Hard	Rapid fat loss, research-backed health benefits, those who prefer "all or nothing" days, metabolic flexibility training	Beginners, anyone with social eating obligations, competitive athletes, those with blood sugar regulation issues

Key Insight: The Best Protocol Is the One You Can Sustain

Research consistently shows that adherence matters more than the specific protocol. A 16:8 fast maintained for 12 months will always outperform a perfect OMAD routine abandoned after 3 weeks. Start easier than you think you need to, then progress once habits are locked in.

Weekly Calorie Impact

16:8: ~10–15% natural deficit
20:4: ~20–30% typical deficit
OMAD: ~30–40% typical deficit
5:2: ~20–25% weekly deficit
ADF: ~30–35% weekly deficit

Progression Path

Weeks 1–2: 14:10 (ease in)
Weeks 3–4: 16:8 (standard)
Months 2–3: 18:6 (intermediate)
Month 4+: 20:4 or OMAD (advanced)
Never jump levels. Earn each transition.

CHAPTER 03

Protocol Selection Guide

Use this decision framework to pick the right fasting protocol for your goals, experience level, and lifestyle.

STEP 1 — EXPERIENCE CHECK

Have you fasted consistently before?

If you've never done intermittent fasting or have less than 4 weeks of experience, start with 16:8. No exceptions. Build the habit foundation before escalating intensity.

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STEP 2 — PRIMARY GOAL

What is your #1 objective right now?

Fat Loss (aggressive): 20:4 Warrior — compresses eating window for deeper calorie restriction
Fat Loss (steady): 16:8 or 5:2 — sustainable deficit without lifestyle disruption
Muscle Gain: 16:8 only — you need adequate feeding time for 3–4 protein-rich meals
Longevity / Autophagy: OMAD or ADF — longer fasts for maximum cellular cleanup
Flexibility: 5:2 — eat normally most days, restrict only twice per week

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STEP 3 — LIFESTYLE FIT

Does this fit your daily schedule?

Work 9–5, social dinners: 16:8 (12pm–8pm) or 5:2
Shift worker / variable hours: 16:8 with flexible window
No social eating pressure: 20:4 or OMAD
Weekends are non-negotiable: 5:2 (fast on weekdays only)

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STEP 4 — TRAINING SYNC

How does this align with your training?

Train in the AM (fasted): 16:8 with first meal post-workout (e.g., train 7am, eat 12pm–8pm)
Train in the PM (fed): 16:8 or 20:4, eat before/after training (e.g., eat 2pm–8pm, train 5pm)
No structured training: Any protocol works — choose based on goals above

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YOUR RESULT

Commit for 4 Weeks Minimum

Give any protocol at least 28 days before evaluating. Track energy, sleep quality, training performance, body composition, and hunger patterns. Adjust only after the adaptation period is complete. Most side effects resolve within 7–10 days.

CHAPTER 04

Meal Timing & Training

How to optimize your workouts within a compressed eating window — and whether fasted training is right for you.

Fasted Training

- Best for: steady-state cardio, light-to-moderate resistance training, fat-loss focus
- Train in final 2–4 hours of fast (e.g., 10am–12pm on a 16:8)
- Higher fat oxidation rate: 20–30% more fat burned vs fed cardio
- May reduce peak power output by 5–10% on heavy compound lifts
- Follow with your first meal within 60 minutes post-workout
- Hydrate with water, black coffee, or electrolytes during session

Fed Training

- Best for: heavy strength training, HIIT, muscle hypertrophy goals
- Eat a meal 2–3 hours before training for optimal performance
- Higher glycogen = better peak power, more reps, heavier loads
- Pre-workout meal: 30–40g protein + 40–60g carbs + low fat
- Post-workout: 30–40g protein + carbs within 2 hours
- Schedule training early in your eating window for two post-workout meals

Sample Training Schedules by Protocol

Protocol	Training Time	Pre-Workout	Post-Workout	Notes
16:8	11:00 AM Fasted	Black coffee + 5g creatine	12:00 PM — large meal with 40g protein, 60g carbs	Ideal for morning lifters; break fast with post-workout meal
16:8	5:00 PM Fed	2:00 PM meal: chicken + rice (500 kcal)	6:30 PM — protein shake + dinner by 8pm	Best for strength; two meals around training
20:4	3:00 PM Near window	Black coffee only (fasted)	4:00 PM — large meal 1, then meal 2 by 8pm	Train just before window opens; maximize feeding time post-workout
OMAD	4:00 PM Fasted	Water + electrolytes	6:00 PM — single large meal (2000+ kcal)	Keep training moderate; hard to fuel heavy sessions with one meal

The BCAA Debate: During Fasting

BCAAs (branched-chain amino acids) technically break a fast because they trigger an insulin response and stimulate mTOR, which halts autophagy. However, if your goal is **muscle preservation during fasted training** (not autophagy), 5–10g BCAAs before a fasted workout may help reduce muscle breakdown. **Our recommendation:** Skip BCAAs if autophagy/longevity is the goal. Use them if you're lean-bulking or in a deep cut and training hard while fasted. Better yet — schedule your training at the end of your fast so your post-workout meal handles recovery.

Supplements That Don't Break a Fast

Black coffee, plain tea, water, electrolytes (no sugar), creatine monohydrate, vitamin D, fish oil (minimal calories), apple cider vinegar

Supplements That DO Break a Fast

BCAAs, protein powder, pre-workouts with sugar/calories, gummy vitamins, collagen peptides, any supplement with >1g protein or sugar

CHAPTER 05

7-Day 16:8 Meal Plan

Eating window: 12:00 PM – 8:00 PM • ~2,000 calories/day • High protein, balanced macros

MON — 2,010 kcal • 165g P / 195g C / 68g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Chicken Stir-Fry Bowl
200g chicken breast, 150g jasmine rice, mixed veggies, soy sauce • 55g P / 65g C / 12g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Greek Yogurt Power Bowl
250g Greek yogurt, 40g granola, banana, 20g honey • 30g P / 70g C / 8g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
Salmon & Sweet Potato
180g salmon fillet, 200g sweet potato, broccoli, olive oil • 80g P / 60g C / 48g F

TUE — 1,985 kcal • 160g P / 200g C / 64g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Turkey Burrito Bowl
200g ground turkey, black beans, rice, salsa, avocado • 50g P / 70g C / 18g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Protein Smoothie
Whey protein, oats, peanut butter, banana, almond milk • 40g P / 60g C / 16g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
Beef & Veggie Stew
200g lean beef, potatoes, carrots, onions, bone broth • 70g P / 70g C / 30g F

WED — 2,020 kcal • 170g P / 190g C / 66g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Egg & Avocado Plate
4 whole eggs, sourdough toast, avocado, spinach • 35g P / 40g C / 32g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Tuna Rice Cakes
2 cans tuna, rice cakes, cucumber, light mayo • 55g P / 50g C / 10g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
Chicken Pasta
180g chicken thigh, 100g penne, marinara, parmesan • 80g P / 100g C / 24g F

THU — 1,995 kcal • 162g P / 198g C / 65g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Shrimp Fried Rice
250g shrimp, 150g rice, egg, peas, sesame oil • 48g P / 68g C / 14g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Cottage Cheese & Fruit
300g cottage cheese, berries, almonds, honey drizzle • 38g P / 45g C / 16g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
Steak & Roasted Veggies
200g sirloin, roasted potatoes, asparagus, butter • 76g P / 85g C / 35g F

FRI — 2,005 kcal • 158g P / 205g C / 67g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Chicken Caesar Wrap
180g chicken, large tortilla, romaine, parmesan, dressing • 45g P / 55g C / 22g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Oat & Protein Pancakes
Oats, whey, eggs, banana, maple syrup • 38g P / 75g C / 12g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
Cod & Quinoa Bowl
200g cod, quinoa, roasted peppers, tahini drizzle • 75g P / 75g C / 33g F

SAT — 2,040 kcal • 155g P / 210g C / 70g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Brunch Omelette
4 eggs, cheese, mushrooms, toast, hash browns • 38g P / 60g C / 30g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Protein Bar + Trail Mix
Protein bar, mixed nuts, dried fruit • 32g P / 55g C / 20g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
BBQ Chicken & Corn
250g chicken thigh, corn on cob, coleslaw, baked beans • 85g P / 95g C / 20g F

SUN — 1,990 kcal • 160g P / 192g C / 68g F

12:00 PM — MEAL 1
Smoked Salmon Bagel
Bagel, 100g smoked salmon, cream cheese, capers • 35g P / 55g C / 18g F

4:00 PM — MEAL 2
Chicken Soup + Bread
Large bowl chicken soup, crusty bread, side salad • 40g P / 62g C / 14g F

7:30 PM — MEAL 3
Lamb Kofta & Couscous
200g lamb kofta, couscous, tzatziki, roasted veg • 85g P / 75g C / 36g F

CHAPTER 06

Breaking Your Fast

What you eat first matters. The wrong foods can spike insulin, cause bloating, and undo the benefits of your fast.

The Ideal Fast-Breaking Sequence

1 Start with Water + Electrolytes (10 min before eating)
Drink 500ml of water with a pinch of sea salt and a squeeze of lemon. This rehydrates your digestive system, primes stomach acid production, and prevents the bloating that comes from eating on a completely empty, dehydrated gut.

2 Protein + Fiber First (your first bite)
Lead with 30–40g of protein (eggs, chicken, fish, Greek yogurt) paired with fiber-rich vegetables or greens. Protein blunts the glucose spike from carbs eaten later. Fiber slows gastric emptying and feeds gut bacteria that were resting during the fast. Never break a fast with pure sugar or refined carbs.

3 Add Healthy Fats (with your meal)
Include a moderate fat source: avocado, olive oil, nuts, or fatty fish. Fats slow digestion further, improve satiety, and help absorb fat-soluble vitamins (A, D, E, K) that you may be supplementing. Avoid fried or heavily processed fats.

4 Complex Carbs Last (15–20 min in)
Save starches and carbs for after protein and fats are in your system. This "food sequencing" can reduce post-meal glucose spikes by up to 40% (research from Weill Cornell Medicine). Rice, potatoes, bread, fruit — all fine, just not first.

Daily Electrolyte Protocol During Fasting

- **Sodium:** 2,000–3,000mg/day — sea salt in water, bone broth, or electrolyte tablets
- **Potassium:** 1,000–2,000mg/day — lite salt (potassium chloride), avocado, spinach in meals
- **Magnesium:** 300–400mg/day — magnesium glycinate before bed (aids sleep + prevents cramps)
- **Hydration:** Minimum 2.5–3.5L water daily, more if training or in hot climates

Common Side Effects & Solutions

Side Effect	Why It Happens	Solution	Timeline
Headaches	Dehydration, caffeine withdrawal, low sodium	Increase water + add salt to morning water; don't cut caffeine simultaneously	Resolves in 3–5 days
Irritability / Brain Fog	Blood sugar adjustment, low electrolytes	Electrolyte supplement; start with 14:10 and progress to 16:8 gradually	Resolves in 5–7 days
Hunger Pangs	Ghrelin (hunger hormone) is clock-trained to meal times	Black coffee, sparkling water, stay busy; hunger comes in waves and passes in 20 min	Resolves in 7–14 days
Bloating After Eating	Eating too fast, too much volume at once, low stomach acid	Break fast with small portion first; eat slowly; add apple cider vinegar pre-meal	Resolves in 1–2 weeks
Poor Sleep	Eating too close to bedtime, elevated cortisol	Finish eating 2–3 hours before bed; magnesium glycinate at night	Resolves in 1–2 weeks

Side Effect	Why It Happens	Solution	Timeline
Low Energy in Workouts	Glycogen depletion during adaptation phase	Train at end of fast (break fast post-workout); use caffeine pre-workout	Resolves in 2–3 weeks

Ready to Master Your Fasting Protocol?

Stop guessing about meal timing, macros, and what to eat. EvoFit Meals gives you personalized fasting-optimized meal plans, auto-generated grocery lists, and trainer-designed nutrition built around your protocol.

Starter	MOST POPULAR Pro	Elite
$9/mo	$19/mo	$39/mo
Basic meal plans IF protocol templates	Custom IF meal plans Macro tracking + grocery lists	1-on-1 trainer coaching Full nutrition + training sync

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This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Consult your healthcare provider before starting any fasting protocol, especially if you have diabetes, are pregnant or nursing, have a history of eating disorders, or take medications that require food. Individual results may vary.